



The rocky north coast between Paul and Ribeira Grande in Santa Antao in the Cape Verde islands.

HENRY THE NAVIGATOR'S EXPENSIVE PROJECT

to open up the coast of Africa (see 1434) was met with scepticism at home in Portugal, until in 1441, one of his ships returned with **gold dust and slaves**, prompting an acceleration of activity. Between 1444 and 1446, around 35 of Henry's vessels sailed for the **West African coast**. In 1445, sailing in one of Henry's new caravels, explorer **Dinis Dias** sighted the mouth of the Senegal River, which offered a trade route deep into the African interior, and rounded **Cape Verde**, the westernmost point of Africa. Dias returned the following year as part of a fleet of caravels intending to plant the Portuguese flag and explore what Henry believed might be the western branch of the Nile, while another of Henry's captains, Nuño Tristão, sighted the Gambia River.

The marriage of **Margaret of Anjou** (c. 1430–82) to Henry VI of England in 1445 was negotiated by William de la Pole, chief advisor to the king and power behind the throne, whose aim was to stop the war in France (see 1435–37). At first, the match and the bride were popular in England, but in 1448, the territory of Maine in northern France was lost to Charles VII and the queen was blamed for her influence over the weak king. Margaret would survive this, however, and become an important player in the **Wars of the Roses** (see 1454–55).

The death of **Filippo Maria Visconti** in 1447 signaled the end of the Visconti ducal line of Milan

(see 1421–22). There were multiple claimants to the ducal throne, and eager to avoid domination by a foreigner, the Milanese powers immediately constituted the *Aurea Repubblica Ambrosiana* of Milan, or the **Ambrosian Republic**, but they faced insurmountable obstacles. Riven by internal dissension and unwilling to lose control of the other cities controlled by Milan, they were soon forced to turn military control over to a *condottiere*, or mercenary soldier-leader—the powerful Muzio Attendolo, nicknamed *Sforza* meaning “exert” or “force.”

In the mid-15th century, the Shona kingdom of **Mwene Mutapa**, also known as Great Zimbabwe (see 1106–10), was nearing the end of its glory days. By this time, the riches of the gold fields had funded construction of the Great Enclosure, an elliptical space enclosed by a giant wall 800ft (244m) around, and up to 36ft (11m) high in places, built from almost a million granite blocks.

Population of Great Zimbabwe

50,000

POPULATION OF LONDON

20,000

Golden age of Great Zimbabwe

In the mid-15th century, the population of Great Zimbabwe was just under half the size of the population of London.



Illustration from a Muromachi period manuscript. The arts flourished in Japan under Ashikaga patronage.

IN 1449, ASHIKAGA YOSHIMASA (1435–90) BECAME SHOGUN, or military dictator, of Japan.

Although his reign marked a cultural highpoint of the Ashikaga, or Muromachi period (1336–1573) it was also a period of increasing civil strife. Repeated famines triggered constant uprisings, while the Ashikaga practice of issuing *tokuseirei* or “acts of grace” to cancel debts, damaged the economy. Despite this, Yoshimasa presided over a cultural flowering at his Higashiyama estate.

The new pope, Nicholas V, elected in 1447, was intent on bringing an end to the schism caused by his predecessor's clash with the **Council of Basel** (see 1435–37), and on restoring peace to Italy and achieving harmonious relations with other rulers. At the **Concordat of Vienna** in 1448, he made concessions to Emperor Frederick III and the other German princes, who in return abandoned the Council of Basel and recognized some papal powers. The following year, the Council of Basel finally disbanded and the anti-pope, Felix V, abdicated in return for a cardinalship. This marked the final **victory of the papacy** over the conciliar movement.

Following the death of Byzantine emperor John VIII, his brother Constantine XI Palaeologus (see panel, right) acceded to the throne in Constantinople—he would be the **last Byzantine emperor**. The Ottomans had defeated another of Jan Hunyadi's crusades to clear



PALAEOLOGUS
(1404–53)

Constantine XI Palaeologus succeeded to the remnants of a once-great empire, left without the resources to defend itself. He was the last emperor of Byzantium, a state that had lasted throughout the medieval period, providing a unique bridge between east and west, ancient and modern. He died on the walls of Constantinople, having done everything in his power to secure its defense.

them from the Balkans at the second Battle of Kosovo in 1448, regaining control of Albania. It was clear that there would be no European rescue for the embattled Byzantines. The Ottomans were closing in on Constantinople.

1443 Skanderbeg (1405–1468) leads Albanian revolt against the Ottomans
November 10, 1444 Ottoman sultan Murad II repels Hungarian-led crusading army at **Battle of Varna**

1445 Zara Ya'qub of Ethiopia (1399–1468) defeats sultan of Ifat, Somalia
c. 1445 Last golden age of Great Zimbabwe
April 23, 1445 Marriage of Margaret of Anjou to Henry VI of England
1445 Portuguese explorer Dinis Dias rounds Cape Verde, West Africa

1446 Death of Deva Raya II (b. 1424) who had expanded Vijayanagar Empire, India, to greatest extent
1447 Casimir IV (1427–92) reunites Lithuania and Poland
1447 Ambrosian Republic founded in Milan

1448 Portuguese build slave-trading fort on Arguin Island, West Africa
1448 Concordat of Vienna
1448 Murad II defeats crusade of Jan Hunyadi at **Second Battle of Kosovo**
1449 Accession of Constantine XI Palaeologus the last Byzantine emperor
1449 Ming dynasty begins rebuilding Great Wall, China
1448 German printer Johannes Gutenberg (c. 1398–1468) borrows money to develop a printing press, Mainz
1449 Chinese emperor Zhengtong (1427–64) captured by Mongols
1449 Rule of Ashikaga Yoshimasa (1435–90) marks height of the Muromachi period, Japan
1449 Triumph of papacy over conciliar movement with dissolution of Council of Basel